believe that the Loch Ness Monster exists, but believing it doesn't change objective reality.

In contrast to animals, whose existence can be verified or disproved through objective tests, states are intersubjective entities. We normally don't notice it, because everybody takes the existence of the United States, China, Russia or Brazil for granted. But there are cases when people disagree about the existence of certain states, and then their intersubjective status emerges. The Israeli–Palestinian conflict, for example, revolves around this matter, because some people and governments refuse to acknowledge the existence of Israel and others refuse to acknowledge the existence of Palestine. As of 2024, the governments of Brazil and China, for example, say that both Israel and Palestine exist; the governments of the United States and Cameroon recognise only Israel's existence; whereas the governments of Algeria and Iran recognise only Palestine. Other cases range from Kosovo, which as of 2024 is recognised as a state by around half of the 193 UN members,[16] to Abkhazia, which almost all governments see as a sovereign territory of Georgia, but which is recognised as a state by Russia, Venezuela, Nicaragua, Nauru and Syria.[17]

Indeed, almost all states pass at least temporarily through a phase during which their existence is contested, when struggling for independence. Did the United States come into existence on 4 July 1776, or only when other states like France and finally the UK recognised it? Between the declaration of US independence on 4 July 1776, and the signing of the Treaty of Paris on 3 September 1783, some people like George Washington believed the United States existed, while other people like King George III vehemently rejected this idea.

Disagreements about the existence of states cannot be resolved by an objective test, such as a DNA survey or a sonar scan. Unlike animals, states are not an objective reality. When we ask whether a particular state exists, we are raising a question about intersubjective reality. If enough people agree that a particular state exists, then it does. It can then do things like sign legally binding agreements with other states as well as NGOs and private corporations.

Of all genres of stories, those that create intersubjective realities have been the most crucial for the development of large-scale human networks. Implanting fake family memories is certainly helpful, but no religions or empires managed to survive for long without a strong belief in the existence